

THIS IS TECHNOLOGY, CULTURE AND SCIENCE WITH A DIFFERENCE, AND THAT DIFFERENCE IS USUALLY ENOUGH TO MAKE MOST NORMAL PEOPLE GO "WTF?"

This month in ALT:

This month, we take a look at some famous fictional swords, we explore some of the coolest new gadgets, we review a few gadgets and also some TV shows and movies.



Military Grade is a marketing ploy

In the actual military, the term means the lowest possible quality to qualify for use by the armed forces. So the companies and products that advertise using the term are just using another meaningless marketing phrase meant to fool gullible consumers. <http://dgit.in/milgrade>

WHAT'S NEW

A civilisation before humans?

A study checked to see if it was even possible to detect the signs of an advanced industrial civilisation from the geological record. If someone were to look at the geological data of the human race in the far future, our time on Earth would be marked by an excess of nitrogen, rare earth metals, synthetic steroids and microscopic plastic particles in the sediments. There would also be shifts in the carbon chemistry and a rise in global temperatures, which could be detected on geological time scales. Turns out, about 56 million years ago, during the Paleocene-Eocene Thermal Maximum the Earth was warmer than the planet is today, along with carbon and

oxygen isotopes spiking in the same way as you would expect from an industrial civilisation. A



few million years later, there was another similar event called the Eocene Layers of Mysterious Origin which left the

oceans anoxic, or without oxygen for millions of years. The spikes are not spiky enough to qualify as hard evidence yet, but the study shows that we can easily miss these signs in the geological record unless we are specifically looking for it.

<http://dgit.in/silurians>

The most mysterious mountain range in the world

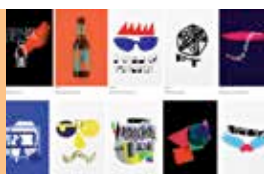
Beneath the ice sheets of the arctic, and below hundreds to thousands of meters of water, is the most mysterious mountain range in the world, called the Lomonosov Ridge. This is a mountain range that is only mapped at a resolution of about a 100 meters, and is caught in a geopolitical struggle between Canada, Greenland and Russia. The complicated international laws mean that as long as the



mountains are a part of continental crust extending from a particular country, that country can claim the extension as their territory as well. Denmark claims it is an extension of Greenland, Russia claims that

it is an extension of Franz Josef Land, a Siberian Archipelago and Canada claims that it is an extension of Ellesmere Island. It is very difficult to reach and map the location but evidence from rock samples suggests two main points, that it is a continental feature, and not an oceanic ridge caused by ocean spreading, and that the folding event of the mountain occurred 470 million years ago.

<http://dgit.in/mstryrng>



This designer was an AI

A mysterious Russian designer called Nikolay Ironov crafted logos for restaurants, influencers, apps and new products. Though the design choices were rather odd, everyone loved them. It was only later that they found out that the designer wasn't human. <http://dgit.in/aidesigner>



Batteries from fruits

Lithium-ion batteries are harmful to the environment throughout their life cycle. Researchers are on the lookout for environmental-friendly alternatives, and one of the promising ideas is to make batteries out of the discarded parts of durian and papayas. <http://dgit.in/fruitbattery>



How to make huggable robots

Robin, a robot created to provide emotional support to sick children, and ergonomically designed to be huggable, managed to convince an 8 year old sick kid to eat her food within 20 minutes, something that the parents and healthcare workers were not able to do. <http://dgit.in/hugbots>